

machine to do some specific task — as part of an office or a home network — for example an email, a database, or a web server. Again, tasks which an older computer is quite capable of handling.

Gordon Moore, the former CEO of Intel once observed that “the power of semiconductor technology doubles every 18 months”, and so the average computer manufactured today has specifications which dwarf those available just a few years ago. But the resource requirement of day-to-day software has not evolved at the same pace. A computer made three years ago will run office, database, accounting and other mainstream applications, and browse the net, as effectively as the latest PC. This is quite a blessing for small businesses looking to purchase a few additional computers, especially in these dire economic times.

“Well what about durability?” you may ask. Jitu Bhai who is the proprietor of Jitu Bhai Joone Computer has some reassuring things to say. As his company’s name suggests, he deals exclusively in second-hand

computers and has been in the business for over ten years. “Computers, although not built to last forever, are certainly built to last. Especially the older ones which had better build quality”, Jitu opines. “[They] almost never break down... if one does fail, chances are that your new PC can also do just that”, says Jitu Bhai. He also points out that it’s a good step you can take to do your bit for the environment. Remember that with very little measure taken for proper disposal of e-waste, most of the redundant PCs in India will be dumped in non-environment-friendly ways. Reuse and reduce is the formula.

Where do these PCs come from?

As we pointed out earlier, one source is the home user, probably indulging in a two-year upgrade cycle. But another important source of these PCs are large companies that have regular update cycles. Companies operating in verticals such as IT, telecom, banking and



Things to keep in mind while buying second-hand PCs

- 1. Avoid Branded PCs. Opt for assembled -** Branded PCs have customised motherboards which are hard to come by. Their slots can't accommodate generic components, the SMPS can't be sourced and numerous other problems. An assembled PC, on the other hand, is easily upgradeable.
- 2. Avoid RD and SD RAM -** Again, these components are very difficult to source. Even if you can source the RAM, it'll be expensive due to non availability.
- 3. Opt for Samsung and LG screens -** These, according to dealers, are the most reliable and they have a wide service network. Like most things Chinese, avoid Chinese monitors.
- 4. Operate the PC to check if its in working order -** Look under the hood for components that are within warranty. For example most hard disk drives come with a 3 year warranty. Also check for bad sectors in the harddisk.
- 5. Check to see if the cooling fan is working properly -** Any abnormal whirring noises could mean it has gathered dust and needs cleaning.
- 6. Give the specs a thorough look to make sure they match with the ones advertised -** Go to Settings > Control Panel > System > Device Manager to check the listed features.
- 7. Try to get original documentation -** Receipts always come in handy.
- 8. Avoid Celerons -** No explanation required!

When you are the seller

When most people sell off their computers, they do a simple formatting of their hard drive. This is certainly not enough. They put themselves at risk of being defrauded or of having their identities stolen because many disks are not properly wiped of data. Second-hand computers are a potential treasure-trove of personal information, and can be exploited to devastating effect. Professor Martin Gill of the University of Leicester and his team, in a study purchased six second-hand computers from various sources and conducted a forensic data-analysis on each one using off the shelf computer software. They discovered half had not been securely wiped. In one case, there had been no attempt to wipe the contents! Make sure you use a data-shredding software on your most personal files before selling your PC. A good data wiping software is Erase v 5.3 which can be downloaded from <http://www.tolvonen.com/eraser/download.shtml>